Expressing feelings and emotions

Objective: To express feelings and emotions accurately using the right adjectives, verbs and structures, and to describe how people react to events.

The idea in two lines: We describe emotions with adjectives (happy, upset), verbs (love, fear) and set phrases (It makes me…). Choosing between **-ed** and **-ing** adjectives, and the right preposition, is what examiners check most.

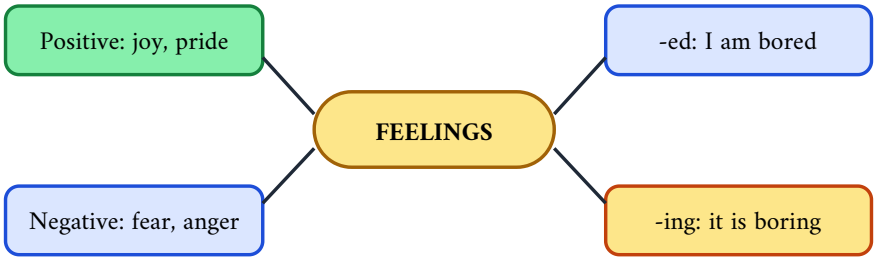


Figure 1: A mind map of feelings: types of emotions and the -ed / -ing adjective contrast.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **-ed adjectives** describe how a person feels: *I was surprised.* **-ing adjectives** describe what causes the feeling: *The news was surprising.*
2. **Adjective + preposition:** afraid *of*, angry *with* someone / *about* something, proud *of*, interested *in*, worried *about*, fond *of*.
3. **Structures:** *It makes me + adjective* (It makes me sad); *I feel + adjective*; *I'm delighted / sorry that + clause*; *I'm glad to + verb*.
4. **Intensifiers:** very, really, so, extremely + gradable adjectives (very angry); absolutely + strong adjectives (absolutely furious, terrified).
5. **Word formation:** noun → adjective with suffixes: joy → joy*ful*, hope → hope*less*, nerve → nerv*ous*, anger → angr*y*; negative prefixes: *un*happy, *dis*appointed.
6. **Verbs of feeling** (love, hate, enjoy, can't stand, fear) are usually stative and followed by a gerund or infinitive: *I can't stand waiting.*

🟢 Examples

1. Choose: The film was so (bored / boring) that I fell asleep. **Answer:** boring. **Explanation:** the film causes the feeling.
2. Complete: She is very proud ___ her son's success. **Answer:** of.
3. Rewrite: "Losing the match made us unhappy." → *We were unhappy because we lost the match.* **Explanation:** the feeling becomes an adjective after *be*, and the cause a clause.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Writing *I am boring* when you mean *I am bored*.
- Using the wrong preposition: *afraid from* instead of *afraid of*.
- Saying *very furious*: strong adjectives take **absolutely** or **really**.
- Confusing nouns and adjectives after *be*: *I am anger* (noun) instead of *I am angry* (adjective).

🟡 Quick review

- -ed = the person's feeling; -ing = the cause.
- Learn each feeling adjective with its preposition.
- It makes me + adjective; I'm glad that + clause.
- Suffixes -ful, -less, -ous, -y build feeling adjectives.
- Very + normal adjective; absolutely + strong adjective.

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